

society & the arts FATHERHOOD

The biggest pressure on dads comes from the new competitive global economy. The fluid job market makes more demands and fewer promises. "It requires people to shoulder more responsibilities and risk," says Himanshu Chakrawarti, 40, coo of Landmark in Chennai, and an over-stretched dad. "People are willing to work longer hours for a better future." Office space has also become more comfortable and conducive for work. "The intrusion of technology—the Internet, e-mails and mobile phones—makes it harder to detach from work," points out the IIT-IM alumnus.

And the family bears the brunt. For many years, a 40-something operations executive with HSBC (who spoke on condition of anonymity) played by his hard-driving boss's rules—"living at work", as he describes it. Then one weekend, his young son fell and cut his knee. To his shock and dismay, the child refused to let the father comfort him. In fact, he treated him like a stranger. The event was a turning point. Although fearful for his job, he approached his boss and said that he had let slip the singlemost important priority in his life—a close relation with his son. "Judge me by the quality of my work, not the amount of time I spend in office," he said. The request led to an uproar, but it probably helped the bank put people first. HSBC today is one of the few companies in India with employee-friendly, flexible policies.

Guilt and regret are the by-word in many a dad's life. Take a day in the life of Rajeev Ramachandra, 40, of Bangalore. As founder of Mistral Software, an embedded software product company with offices around the world, he's on call 24x7. He logs in at



work by 9 a.m. and leaves almost 12 hours later, bringing work home every day and working for at least two hours. That leaves him with an hour or so of free time, when he tries to relax, have his evening meals and spend time with his children. This, mind you, is one of his better parenting days. Nearly three weeks every quarter he's on tour. "I feel I don't give my children enough time. I try hard to keep my weekends free for them," Ramachandra says ruefully.

73% TEENAGERS PREFER

Consider L. Viswanathan, 35, partner with leading Mumbai law firm Amarchand & Mangaldas. His work easily takes up 14 hours on a weekday, most Saturdays and sometimes Sundays. Nearly four times a month it takes him away from home. "It's painful when your little girl cries and clings to you every morning to stop you from going to work," he says. Little

a day in the life of a harried dad



3 a.m.

BlackBerry vibrates. Call from dad's US office for a meeting via teleconferencing. A deal needs to be finalised by following day. Dad struggles to go back to sleep.



6.30 a.m.

Alarm goes off. Dad wakes up groggy and decides to go for a jog. Fires off sms-es to his staff before sprinting into the crosswalk with his i-Mate. Perfect time to grab the boss's ear.



7:15 a.m.

Dad wakes the kids up for breakfast, catches the news on the telly, keeps an eye on the toddler and takes a look at 10-year-old son's class project. Rushes to get ready for office.



9:30 a.m.

Dad logs in at office. Late by a half hour today. Got delayed by his baby crying and clinging on to his trouser leg. Nasty traffic snarl in front of older boy's school, too.



7:30 p.m.

Conference call with the US office ends. Dad feels obliged to go out for a drink with colleagues and clients. He calls it a day and logs off.